

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN PAINTINGS

MODULE - 3

**MURAL PAINTINGS
OF INDIA**

LATER MURAL TRADITIONS



AJANTA MURALS

- 1 Even after Ajanta, very few sites with paintings have survived which provide valuable evidences to reconstruct the tradition of paintings.
- 2 It may also be noted that the sculptures too were plastered and painted.
- 3 The tradition of cave excavations continued further at many places where sculpting and painting were done simultaneously.

MURAL TRADITIONS

7

MURALS UNDER PALLAVAS



The Mandagapattu inscription that mentions Mahendravarman I

- 1 The tradition of painting extended further down south in Tamil Nadu in the preceding centuries with regional variations during the regimes of Pallava, Pandya and Chola dynasties.
- 2 The Pallava kings who succeeded the Chalukya kings in parts of South India, were great patrons of arts.
- 3 Mahendravarman I who ruled in the seventh century was responsible for building temples at Panamalai, Mandagapattu and Kanchipuram.

MURAL TRADITIONS

7

MURALS UNDER PALLAVAS



A painting in Panamalai showing a well adorned, graceful young lady standing beneath a royal parasol, wearing a tall bejewelled kirita (tiara) and jewellery typical of the Pallava period

4

The inscription at Mandagapattu mentions Mahendravarman I with numerous titles such as **Vichitrachitta** (curious-minded), **Chitrakarapuli** (tiger among artists), **Chaityakari** (temple builder), which show his interest in art activities.

5

The paintings in these temples too were done at his initiative, though only fragments remain.

6

The **Panamalai figure** of a female divinity is drawn gracefully.

7

Paintings at the **Kanchipuram** temple were patronised by the **Pallava king, Rajsimha**.

MURAL TRADITIONS

8

MURALS UNDER PANDYAS



Sittanavasal murals

- 1 When the Pandyas rose to power, they too patronised art. Tirumalaipuram caves and Jaina caves at Sittanavasal are some of the surviving examples
- 2 A few fragmented layers of paintings can be seen in Tirumalaipuram.
- 3 In Sittanavasal, the paintings are visible on the ceilings of shrines, in verandas, and on the brackets.
- 4 On the pillars of the veranda are seen dancing figures of celestial nymphs.

MURAL TRADITIONS

8

MURALS UNDER PANDYAS



Sittanavasal jain murals

- 5 The contours of figures are firmly drawn and painted in vermillion red on a lighter background. The body is rendered in yellow with subtle modelling.
- 6 Supple limbs, expression on the faces of dancers, rhythm in their swaying movement, all speak of the artists' skill in creative imagination in visualising the forms in the architectural context.
- 7 Their eyes are slightly elongated and at times protrude off the face.
- 8 This feature is observed in many subsequent paintings in the Deccan and South India.

MURAL TRADITIONS

9

MURALS UNDER CHOLAS



Murals in Brihadeeswara temple

- 1 The tradition of building temples and embellishing them with carvings and paintings continued during the reign of the Chola kings who ruled over the region from the ninth to the thirteenth century.
- 2 But it was in the eleventh century, when the Cholas reached their zenith of power, that masterpieces of Chola art and architecture began to appear.
- 3 The temples of Brihadeswara at Thanjavur, Gangaikonda Cholapuram and Darasuram were built during the reigns of Rajaraja Chola and his son, Rajendra Chola.

MURAL TRADITIONS

9

MURALS UNDER CHOLAS



Nayak period of paintings

- 4 Though Chola paintings are seen in Nartamalai, the most important are those in Brihadeswara temple.
- 5 The paintings were executed on the walls of the narrow passage surrounding the shrine.
- 6 Two layers of paint were found when they were discovered. The upper layer was painted during the Nayak period, in the sixteenth century.

MURAL TRADITIONS

9

MURALS UNDER CHOLAS



Rajaraja and his mentor Kuruvar

7

Thanks to the **cleaning of the surface painting**, examples of the great tradition of painting during the Chola Period were unveiled.

8

The paintings show narrations and aspects related to Lord Shiva, Shiva in Kailash, Shiva as Tripurantaka, Shiva as Nataraja, a portrait of the patron Rajaraja and his mentor Kuruvar, dancing figures, etc.

MURAL TRADITIONS

10

VIJAYANAGARA MURALS

- 1 The paintings of Brihadeswara temple exemplify the stylistic maturity the artists evolved over the years.
- 2 Sinuous pre-determined flow of lines, supple modelling of figures, elongation of the physiognomic features of human figures— all these represent the perfection the Chola artist had achieved during the period on the one hand and the phase of transition on the other.
- 3 With the decline of power of the Chola dynasty in the thirteenth century, the Vijayanagara Dynasty captured and brought under its control the region from Hampi to Trichy with Hampi serving as its capital.
- 4 Many paintings survive in a number of temples. The paintings at Tiruparakunram, near Trichy, done in the fourteenth century represent the early phase of the Vijayanagara style.

MURAL TRADITIONS

10

VIJAYANAGARA MURALS

- 5 In Hampi, the **Virupaksha temple** has paintings on the ceiling of its mandapa narrating events from dynastic history and **episodes from the Ramayana and the Mahabharata**.



**Virupaksha temple
in Hampi**

MURAL TRADITIONS

10

VIJAYANAGARA MURALS



Murals of Virupaksha temple

6

Among the important panels are the ones which show **Vidyaranya**, the spiritual teacher of **Bukkaraya Harsha**, being carried in a palanquin in a procession and the incarnations of Vishnu.

7

The faces of the figures are shown in profile, with large frontal eyes. The figures have narrow waists.

MURAL TRADITIONS

10

VIJAYANAGARA MURALS



Dakshinamurthy mural in Lepakshi

- 8 In **Lepakshi**, near Hindupur, in present Andhra Pradesh, there are glorious examples of **Vijayanagara paintings** on the walls of the Shiva temple.
- 9 In keeping with the tradition, the Vijayanagara painters evolved a pictorial language wherein the faces are shown in profile and figures and objects two-dimensionally.
- 10 Lines become still but fluid, compositions appear in rectilinear compartments

MURAL TRADITIONS

11

NAYAKA MURALS



Nayaka murals in Srirangam

- 1 These stylistic conventions of the preceding centuries were adopted by artists in various centres in South India as can be seen in the paintings of the Nayaka Period.
- 2 Nayaka paintings of the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries are seen in Thiruparakunram, Sreerangam and Tiruvarur.
- 3 In Thiruparakunram, paintings are found of two different periods—of the 14th and the 17th century.
- 4 Early paintings depict scenes from the life of Vardhaman Mahavira.

MURAL TRADITIONS

11

NAYAKA MURALS



Sages Patanjali and Vyaghrapada in the Chidambaram Nataraja Temple

- 5 The Nayaka paintings depict episodes from the **Mahabharata** and the **Ramayana** and also scenes from **Krishna-Leela**.
- 6 In **Chidambaram**, there are panels of paintings narrating stories related to **Shiva** and **Vishnu**— **Shiva** as **Bhikshatana murti**, **Vishnu** as **Mohini**, etc.
- 7 In the **Sri Krishna temple** at **Chengam** in **Arcot District**, there are sixty panels narrating the story of the **Ramayana** which represents the late phase of **Nayaka** paintings.

MURAL TRADITIONS

11

NAYAKA MURALS



Nataraja mural of Nayaka style

- 8 The examples cited above suggest that Nayaka paintings were more or less an extension of the Vijayanagara style with minor regional modifications and incorporations.
- 9 The figures, mostly in profile, are set against a flat background.
- 10 Male figures are shown slim-waisted but with less heavy abdomen as compared to those in Vijayanagara.
- 11 The artist, as in the previous centuries and following traditions, has tried to infuse movement and make the space dynamic. The painting of Nataraja at Tiruvalanjuli is a good example.

MURAL TRADITIONS

12

KERALA MURALS



Kalam ezhuthu of Kerala

- 1 Kerala painters (during the period from the sixteenth to the eighteenth century) evolved a **pictorial language and technique** of their own while discriminately adopting certain stylistic elements from Nayaka and Vijayanagara schools.
- 2 The painters evolved a language taking cues from contemporary traditions like **Kathakali and kalam ezhuthu** using vibrant and luminous colours, representing human figures in three-dimensionality.
- 3 Most of the paintings are seen on the walls of shrines and cloister walls of temples and some inside palaces.

MURAL TRADITIONS

12

KERALA MURALS



Murals of Padmanabhapuram Palace

- 4 Thematically too, paintings from Kerala stand apart.
- 5 Most of the narrations are based on those episodes from Hindu mythology which were popular in Kerala.
- 6 The artist seems to have derived sources from oral traditions and local versions of the Ramayana and the Mahabharata for painted narration.
- 7 More than sixty sites have been found with mural paintings which include three palaces— Dutch palace in Kochi, Krishnapuram palace in Kayamkulam and Padmanabhapuram palace.

MURAL TRADITIONS

12

KERALA MURALS



The mural of Nataraja with 20 arms at the Vadakkunathan temple in Thrissur

8

Among the sites where one can see the mature phase of Kerala's mural painting tradition are Pundareekapuram Krishna temple, Panayanarkavu, Thirukodithanam, Triprayar Sri Rama temple and Thrissur Vadakkunathan temple.

9

Even today we observe that mural painting on interior and exterior walls of houses in villages or havelis is prevalent in different parts of the country.

MURAL TRADITIONS

13

OTHER TRADITIONAL MURALS



Pithoro paintings of Rajasthan

1

These paintings are usually made by women either at the time of ceremonies or festivals or as a routine to clean and decorate the walls.

2

Some of the traditional forms of murals are

- Pithoro in parts of Rajasthan and Gujarat,
- Mithila painting in northern Bihar's Mithila region,
- Warli paintings in Maharashtra, or
- simply paintings on the walls, be it in a village of Odisha or Bengal, Madhya Pradesh or Chhattisgarh.

MURAL TRADITIONS

13

OTHER TRADITIONAL MURALS



Mithila or Madhubani paintings



Warli paintings

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